

Final project rubric

The entire final project comprises 35% of your final grade. It is due on Tuesday, June 30 at 11:59pm on Brightspace. You will be graded according to the following rubric:

1. Articulating a research question (20%)

You should have in mind a clear research question. This shouldn't be too broad (e.g., how does culture affect cognition?) or too narrow (e.g., what are the precise ratio limits of numbers that infants are sensitive to at different ages? Is it 1:6 or 1:5.77960...). Your questions should be roughly of the grain of the empirical articles that we have read in class so far—take a look at some of the articles we've read for an idea of what these should look like.

Make sure your question is well-motivated. Don't just look at something that adults do and ask when kids start to do that as well. Think about *why* kids do it when they do it—think about the developmental processes that are involved in the ability you're thinking about and ask questions about the mechanisms underlying or enabling it.

2. Setting up alternative hypotheses (10%)

Lay out alternative hypotheses that reflect your research question and explain what each of them predict. You should include a 'fork' where you explain the predictions of each of your alternative hypotheses. This should be of the form: "If H1 is true, we should see ... On the other hand, if H2 is true, we should see ...". Marshall et al. (2021, p. 362, left column) is a great example of this.

You could make a particular prediction, but if you honestly think the data could go either way, you could also lay out the hypotheses without predicting either over the other. The experiment should plausibly go either way—before running the experiment, we shouldn't know how the data turn out (although we might have good guesses). These will be graded on the clarity of the two different hypotheses and how they connect to the introduction and methods in the rest of the paper.

3. Methods (30%)

Explain what methods you're going to use and what data you're going to obtain to decide between your hypotheses. The study needs to be an experiment, meaning you have to manipulate something and see if it has an effect on some other variable. Describe what your sample is, what the procedure of the study is, and how you will be using randomization in your design. Take a look at any of the empirical papers we've read this semester to get a sense of what these should look like.

Some papers really benefit from a good methods figure. I strongly recommend one. You might save space because you won't have to describe the methods in as much detail—you can refer to the figure to make points about the methods.

4. Predictions and Discussion (30%)

End by laying out your predicted results and some discussion of what your results would tell us. Again, these should be stated at the right grain—not at the level of “This experiment shows that culture affects cognition”. This should tie back to the questions you set up in the introduction.

5. Clarity of writing (10%)

Again, the writing should be clear. Work from an outline. Lay out a good argument. Structure the paragraphs so that each one makes a specific point. Back up each claim with evidence. Revise your outline if needed, but make sure it’s coherent after your writing is all done.

One useful way to think about the structure of your paper is like an hourglass—your introduction should start off broad, and then turn to the more specific, narrow questions you have in mind. The methods and predictions should have enough detail for others reading your paper to reconstruct your experiment and understand the logic behind the predictions. Your discussion should then take your (predicted) results and then broaden back out to see how it bears on bigger picture debate. The hourglass isn’t perfect—for example, the discussion could mention little details in your methods—but that’s the rough shape of a paper.

If you’re not sure what a certain part of your paper should look like, take a look at some of the other well-written papers we’ve read (maybe Marshall et al.?), and make it just like theirs. Or you could ask Angela and me for feedback. We won’t provide line-by-line feedback on your drafts, but we can look at them and give you more general feedback.